Kanshi Ram was a Dalit anti-caste activist and founder of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP). Born in Punjab, he believed that Dalits and other marginalized groups (the ‘bahujan’ or many) needed to fight for their rights and an egalitarian society. He encouraged Dalits to take pride in their origins, and argued that the marginalized could only truly create social change by wielding political power. To this end, he founded the BSP in 1984. Thanks to his efforts to build a support base, the party gradually gained ground and finally won its first parliamentary seats in 1989. Since then, the party has had a strong presence in the state of Uttar Pradesh.

**House here means Parliament.*